

General Knowledge

Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Satvahanas



Post Mauryan - Satvahanas



Introduction to the Satavahana Dynasty

- The **Satavahanas** emerged as the most significant **regional power** in the **Deccan** following the decline of the **Mauryan Empire** around the **2nd century BCE**.
- They ruled over **modern-day Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Telangana, and Madhya Pradesh**.
- Known as **Andhras** in the **Puranas**, they built the **first major kingdom in the Deccan**, marking a **transition from Mauryan control to regional powers**.
- **Capital Cities:** **Pratishthana (Paithan)** and **Amaravati**.
- **Political Role:** The Satavahanas acted as a **bridge between North and South India**, integrating **local Deccan culture with northern traditions**.

Political History of the Satavahana Dynasty

Ruler	Period	Achievements and Contributions
Simuka	60 BCE – 37 BCE	Founder of the dynasty and Mentioned in the Naneghat inscription .
Satakarni I	70 BCE – 60 BCE	Expanded territory into the Malwa and Narmada valleys . Mentioned in the Hathigumpha inscription of Kharavela .
Hala	20 CE – 24 CE	Compiled Gatha Saptasati , a Maharashtri Prakrit anthology of love poems . He was known as a patron of literature and mentioned in Matsya Purana .
Gautamiputra Satakarni	106 CE – 130 CE	Revived Satavahana power and defeated Shakas, Pahlavas, and Yavanas . He was described as Ekabrahmana (the unique Brahmin) in the Nasik Prashasti .
Vashisthiputra Pulumavi	130 CE – 154 CE	Mentioned in Junagadh inscriptions and married the daughter of Rudradaman I (a Shaka ruler).
Yajna Sri Satakarni	165 CE – 194 CE	Known as the last great ruler .

Simuka (60 BCE – 37 BCE) – Founder of the Satavahana Dynasty

- **Founder of the dynasty**, Simuka laid the **foundations of Satavahana rule** by defeating local rulers in **Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh**.
- **Alliance with Rathikas and Bhojakas**: Established early power through alliances with **local warrior tribes**.
- Mentioned in the **Naneghat inscription** as the first significant ruler of the dynasty.
- His reign marked the end of **Shunga control in the Deccan**.

- Simuka was succeeded by his brother, **Kanha**.

Satakarni I (70 BCE – 60 BCE) – The Lord of Dakshinapatha

- Satakarni I expanded the Satavahana Empire to the **Malwa and Narmada regions** by defeating **local rulers**.
- Known as the **Lord of Dakshinapatha** (southern route), a title mentioned in the **Naneghat inscription** written by his wife, **Queen Nayanika**.
- Conquered parts of **Western Malwa** and **central India**, and performed **two Ashvamedha sacrifices**, symbolizing his **sovereignty**.
- **Engagement with Kharavela**: As mentioned in the **Hathigumpha inscription**, Satakarni I fought against **Kalinga** under **Kharavela**.



Hala (20 CE – 24 CE) – Patron of Literature

- Known for compiling the **Gatha Saptasati**, a **Prakrit anthology of love poems**.
- Promoted **literature and arts**, earning recognition in the **Matsya Purana**.
- His reign is considered peaceful, focusing on **internal development** and **literary contributions** rather than military conquests.

Gautamiputra Satakarni (106 CE – 130 CE) – The Reviver of Satavahana Power

- **Gautamiputra Satakarni** is regarded as the most **powerful Satavahana ruler** who revived the **empire's strength** by defeating the **Shakas, Pahlavas, and Yavanas**.
- **Nasik Prashasti**: His achievements were inscribed by his mother, **Gautami Balashri**, highlighting his **conquests and patronage to Brahmanism**.
- His empire stretched from **Malwa, Saurashtra, and Konkan** to **Vidarbha and Krishna River** in the south.
- Known for **restoring the pride of Brahmins** and **defeating the Shaka king Nahapana**, he expanded the **empire's borders considerably**.
- Despite his focus on **Brahmanism**, Gautamiputra Satakarni made **land grants to Buddhist monks**, promoting **religious harmony**.

Vashisthiputra Pulumavi (130 CE – 154 CE) – Diplomatic Marriages and Expansion

- Pulumavi extended the **empire's southern borders** to the mouth of the **Krishna River**.
- **Coins bearing ship motifs** indicate his efforts to **promote overseas trade**.
- His marriage to the daughter of **Rudradaman I**, a Shaka king, is mentioned in the **Junagadh inscription**, showcasing **marital diplomacy**.

Yajna Sri Satakarni (165 CE – 194 CE) – The Last Great Satavahana King

- Known as the **last powerful ruler** of the Satavahana dynasty, Yajna Sri Satakarni **recovered Malwa and Konkan** from the Shakas.
- His **coins with ship images** reflect the **importance of maritime trade** during his reign.

- Following his reign, the **empire began to decline**, and it fragmented into **smaller kingdoms**.

Administration of the Satavahana Dynasty

Decentralized Governance and Structure

- The **Satavahanas retained several administrative features** from the **Mauryan Empire** but tailored them to **local needs**.
- Emphasis on regional control and military governance** with **feudal elements** to maintain their vast territories.

Administrative Divisions

Division	Description	Head/Official in Charge
Janapada	Largest administrative unit, similar to a province .	-
Rashtra	Sub-province or regional unit within the Janapada.	Rashtrika or Maharathi (if larger)
Ahara	Equivalent to a district in modern terms.	Amatyas or Mahamatras
Vishaya	Subdivision within Aharas, smaller administrative units.	-
Grama	Village-level division , smallest administrative unit.	Gramani (village head) or Gaulmika (military head)

Feudatory System

Grade	Role/Description	Region of Influence
Rajas	Highest grade; minted coins in their names.	Various Satavahana provinces.

Mahabhojas	Influential feudatories, particularly in Thane and Kolaba districts.	Western Deccan.
Maharathis	Regional chiefs with considerable local authority .	Poona district.

Military Administration

Military Division	Description
Katakas	Temporary military camps act as administrative centres.
Skandhavaras	Permanent military cantonments with administrative functions.

- **Gaulmika**: Military head of rural areas, overseeing **nine chariots, 25 horses, and 45 foot soldiers**.
- **Senapati**: A late addition to the feudal system, serving as both a **military commander** and a **provincial governor**.

Key Officers and Their Roles

Officer Title	Role and Responsibility
Raja (King)	Head of the state, commonly addressed as Rajan . Used Maharaja title sparingly.
Raj-Amatyas	Senior ministers formed the king's council.
Senapati	Commander of the army and provincial governor .
Rajjuka	Revenue officer , responsible for tax collection .
Bhandagarika	Treasurer , in charge of the royal treasury.
Paniyagharika	Superintendent of waterworks , managing irrigation and water supply.
Karmantika	Superintendent of public works , overseeing infrastructure projects.
Avesanika	Foreman , supervising artisans and craftsmen.

Art and Architecture During the Satavahana Period

Structure	Location	Key Features
Amaravati Stupa	Andhra Pradesh	- Built during the 3rd century BCE. - Depicts Jataka tales and life events of Buddha. - Discovered by Colin Mackenzie.
Nagarjunakonda Stupa	Andhra Pradesh	- Patronised by the Ikshvaku rulers. - Known for Buddhist carvings.
Karle Chaitya	Maharashtra	- The largest rock-cut Chaitya hall. - Decorated with ornate sculptures.
Ajanta Caves	Maharashtra	- Caves 9 and 10 were developed under Satavahana patronage. - Depicts Buddhist narratives and Jataka stories.

Economy During the Satavahana Period

- **Agriculture:**
 - The **Krishna-Godavari Delta** served as a **major rice-producing region**.
 - The use of **paddy transplantation techniques** helped enhance agricultural productivity.
- **Trade and Commerce:**
 - **Trade Routes:** Uttarapatha (northern trade route) and Dakshinapatha (southern trade route).
 - **Ports:** Key ports included **Kalyani, Sopara, Bharuch, and Ganjam**.
- **Coinage:**
 - Issued coins in **lead, copper, and bronze**, with **animal motifs** and **Prakrit inscriptions**.
 - Coins featured **ships and Chaityas**, indicating the **importance of maritime trade**.

Religion and Society During the Satavahana Period

- **Religious Practices:**
 - The Satavahanas were **Brahmins** but promoted **Buddhism** by making **land grants to Buddhist monks**.
 - Performed **Vedic sacrifices** such as **Ashvamedha and Rajasuya**.
- **Social Structure:**
 - Society followed the **Varna system**, with merchants and artisans gaining importance due to **thriving trade**.
 - **Matronymic Tradition:** Kings were often named after their **mothers**, indicating the importance of women in Satavahana society.
- **Position of Women:**
 - **Nayanika** and **Gautami Balashri** played influential roles, with Nayanika serving as regent for her minor son.

Decline of the Satavahana Dynasty

- **Internal Weaknesses:** The dynasty weakened due to **ineffective rulers** after **Yajna Sri Satakarni**.
- **Feudal Fragmentation:** The rise of **feudatories** and loss of **central authority** further divided the empire.
- **Emergence of Successor Kingdoms:**
 - **Ikshvakus** in Andhra Pradesh.
 - **Abhiras and Chutus** in Maharashtra.
 - **Pallavas** in Tamil Nadu.